

Taylor & Francis
Taylor & Francis Group

CoDesign

International Journal of CoCreation in Design and the Arts

ISSN: 1571-0882 (Print) 1745-3755 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/ncdn20

Deliberating, designing, and doing situated ethics in citizen collaborations

Suzanna Törnroth & Minna Eronen

To cite this article: Suzanna Törnroth & Minna Eronen (11 Mar 2026): Deliberating, designing, and doing situated ethics in citizen collaborations, CoDesign, DOI: 10.1080/15710882.2026.2640145

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/15710882.2026.2640145

© 2026 The Author(s). Published by Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group.

Published online: 11 Mar 2026.

Submit your article to this journal

View related articles

View Crossmark data

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=ncdn20

CODESIGN
https://doi.org/10.1080/15710882.2026.2640145

Taylor & Francis
Taylor & Francis Group

OPEN ACCESS Check for updates

Deliberating, designing, and doing situated ethics in citizen collaborations

Suzanna Törnroth and Minna Eronen

Design Research Group, Department of Social Sciences, Technology & Arts, Luleå University of Technology, Luleå, Sweden

ABSTRACT

Collaborative design is a complex practice in which designer (-researchers) and non-designers share their knowledge and experiences for co-production. How collaboration is conducted is often ridden with power tensions and ethical entanglements that require sensitive navigation. Contributing to the discourse at the nexus of ethics and collaborative design, this article proposes a thinking framework around situated ethics – a pantogram mapping four dimensions of ideal designer and citizen embodiment in collaborative acts. A case study follows, exemplifying how the framework can be applied in practice, focusing on ethical collaborative designing with citizens towards a new neighbourhood square. The article culminates in a proposal for ethical behaviour that is not only meaningful but also viable and reflexive enough to adapt and perform for collaborative in-person activities.

ARTICLE HISTORY
Received 18 October 2025
Accepted 26 February 2026

KEYWORDS
Ethics; collaborative design; situated design; citizen science; methods

1. Introduction

Collaboration is a delicate ecology of power dynamics, creative expression, and communication. In co-creative practices and co-design, when participants feel that they can express and share their experiences, their potential of engaging in exploring variety of problems may lead to incease in functional and meaningful solutions (Sanders and Stappers 2008; Steen 2013). Therefore, *the way* these situations are conducted plays an important role from the ethical point of view (Akama and Light 2020). However, in the context of research, ethics tend to refer to normative guidelines and legal considerations based on rules rather than reflectivity (Frauenberger, Rauhala, and Fitzpatrick 2016). Even though professional organisations aid in safeguarding the ethical practices by providing professional code of conducts, these kinds of guidelines often remain quite general and may lack 'character – and relationship-based approaches' (Banks 2012, p. 263). Therefore, the aim of this article is to contribute to these issues from the perspective of the situated performance of those involved. We argue that research ethics – in particular, its application in collaborative design research practice – should transcend beyond normative guidelines, towards

CONTACT Suzanna Törnroth suzanna.tornroth@ltu.se

© 2026 The Author(s). Published by Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group.
This is an Open Access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution License (http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/), which permits unrestricted use, distribution, and reproduction in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited. The terms on which this article has been published allow the posting of the Accepted Manuscript in a repository by the author(s) or with their consent.

a deeper consideration of an ethical way-of-being that contributes to human flourishing (d'Anjou 2020; Xue, van Kooten, and Desmet 2025). The research question that guides this article is thus: *How might design researchers more deeply deliberate their ethical positionings so that they might increase their situated awareness and reflectivity when collaborating with various partners?*

To ascertain a collaborative design research act that is not only productive but also conducive to human flourishing, it is necessary that the researcher understands and embraces both the tangible and intangible worlds that entail collaborative design research. The tangible world of collaborative design research can be understood as visible actions and artefacts existing within the material world, while the intangible world can be understood as the invisible thoughts, beliefs, values, and perceptions that guide and form actions and artefacts (Hakio and Mattelmäki 2019). These inner and outer worlds are where collaborative design research is inherently connected to ethics (Lloyd 2009; Steen 2013; Xue, van Kooten, and Desmet 2025), by way of navigating and organically enacting ethics in the moment – in a specific situation. Such spontaneous and potentially surprising meeting of things, people and experience or stories in collaborative design leads to a certain *reflection-in-action* (Schön 1983), where knowledge is generated through the act of (co)making and experimentation. The objects and the depth of the reflective activity can vary, as they are inevitably dependent on one's reflective sensitivity.

Considering the above, Drain and Sanders (2019) Collaboration System Model (CSM) thus offers a foundation upon which this article is based on. The CSM is described as a model of guidance to improve future participatory design (PD) projects by explicitly considering different dimensions during process planning: society and culture, design environment and materials, designers' existing knowledge and activities, and participants' existing knowledge and capacity to participate (Drain and Sanders 2019). More importantly, they argue, are the interactions existing and emerging between these different dimensions. They outline two areas for future research, which this article responds to *(1) unpacking further personal and social complexities that influence the process of collaborative design and (2) the power dynamics across roles and activities of a PD project*. Relatedly, DiSalvo (2022) discusses the labour, locality, and cultures of community participation, importantly emphasising the need for diverse values, agencies, and dissensus following the integration of citizen perspectives – and citizens themselves – into design research. Furthering this discourse, alongside other research in the field of designing for policy and the public sector (e.g. Kimbell et al. 2022; Pirinen et al. 2022), this article spotlights the realistic embodiment and performance of ethics within these collaborative design practices.

In the following sections, we first outline the article's approach and methodology. We then offer a wider philosophical deliberation over what ethics could mean within collaborative design research, primarily through the lens of power, virtue, reflection, and communication and context. Through this, we conceptualise a reflective framework for researchers to conduct *situated ethics* within collaborative design research practices with citizens. We then elucidate the use of this framework through a case study performed in Luleå, where a survey and a pop-up workshop with local inhabitants on the design of a future urban neighbourhood square exemplify the use of the framework at two stages of engagement. Finally, the article culminates in our proposal of ethical ways-

of-being, along with challenges and opportunities for the framework's future implementation.

2. Approach and methodology

Our approach to this study takes on an overarching introspective characterisation, where personal insights and development occur through 'looking inwards' (e.g. Xue and Desmet 2019; Xue, van Kooten, and Desmet 2025). Xue and Desmet (2019) explain that 'a designer's empathy (i.e. to experience and understand what the users experience) is only half of the story; designer's introspection on the basis of empathy (i.e. examining and interpreting empathised experiences in order to generate design insights and envision new experiences) is the latter half that is under-examined' (p. 39). Furthering that line of thought, Frauenberger, Rauhala, and Fitzpatrick (2016) posit that ethics is a shared responsibility among all stakeholders involved within a situated context – it is co-constructed – which encourages openness and transparency about how ethical judgements are made. Particularly within the scope of collaborative design, Drain and Sanders (2019) argue that, 'it is imperative that PD practitioners reflect on who is actually making important design decisions and how they are empowering participants to contribute to, and lead, the evaluation of alternative project directions' (p. 49).

This article thus offers a novel contribution at the nexus of applied ethics and collaborative design research – towards *situated ethics*. We operationalise a dialogical case study methodology (Rule and John 2015) for this purpose, where the knowledge is developed in iterative process between theory and empirical findings. This includes documenting structured team reflective sessions, journaling practices, periodic team discussions, or guided self-interviewing techniques. According to Rule and John (2015), a case study built on such an approach might more clearly link theory and real-world application in an iterative, bidirectional way through a combination of, 'inductive, theory-building approach (theory for the case) and a deductive, theory-testing approach (theory from the case)' (Rule and John 2015, 1). Our case study thus serves as an illustrative way of how our framework could be applied.

The case study, primarily a survey and a pop-up workshop with local inhabitants within the neighbourhood of Kronan, was part of a larger municipal development scheme in 2020. It was a short-term project of approximately 6 months, which was commissioned by the local municipality to gather insight from citizens on how they would like the new neighbourhood square to be developed. The activities conducted were aimed to understand the needs of those living within the area, as well as to inspire experimental, innovative, and anticipatory ways of designing the future square. Our role was to lead citizen engagament within the project – particularly in the planning, facilitation, and analysis of the generated data.

3. Ethical behaviour in collaborations – *deliberating*

The system of power relations – how power is formed, taken, or given, and distributed – in collaborative design research is a fragile one. This section discusses the different perceived roles of researchers and various partners as well as elucidates on the junctures

between design ethics and power, and how these manifests in socio-material settings. Situated ethics, which our proposed framework later calls for, is influenced by these different forms and characterisations of power.

3.1. On roles and expertise

In design research collaborations, design researchers may participate as enablers who make things happen, facilitators who guide the process, actors who help to reflect and motivate inclusion, observers who aid in data collection and documentation, and translators who translate ideas into solutions (Sanders and Stappers 2008; Zamenopoulos and Alexiou 2018). The role of the non-designer partners is generally understood in terms of being the expert of their lived experiences (Sanders and Stappers 2008). To acknowledge that all participants are indeed experts of their own reality requires trust and acceptance that the self-reported experiences are true and valid. This entails a respectful navigation of possibly conflicting realms of values and views. Thus, the binary distinction between researchers and various partners' collapses, giving way to plural notions on what it means to be an expert. Furthermore, self-awareness of one's experience-based expertise may be empowering (Zamenopoulos et al. 2021). Consequently, defining one's own role and position can be seen as an ethical statement (Akama and Light 2020).

However, as researchers tend to occupy the role of the leader, their task is to create possibilities for other participants to acknowledge and express their expertise. This requires an enabling attitude: keeping an open mind and creating both physical and cognitive spaces for innovative collaboration based on trust and creativity (Peschl and Fundneider 2014). Thus, the essence of collaborative acts can be condensed to the capacity for shared decision authority. Powers within knowledge co-production processes are not only negotiated between researchers and various partners but they are also distributed according to the participants' level of involvement (Arnstein 1969; Herr and Anderson 2014), as seen in Figure 1.

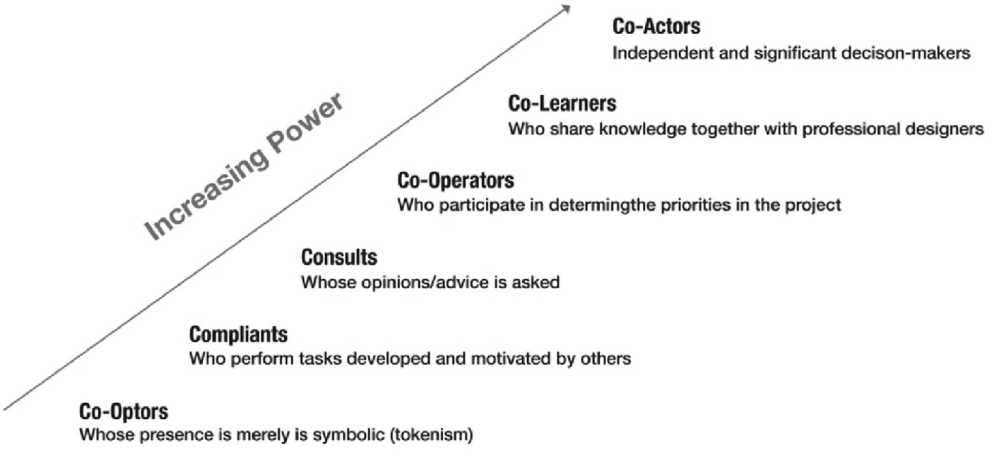


Figure 1. The roles of the collaborative design research partners. Authors' own visualisation, inspired by Herr and Anderson (2014) and Arnstein (1969). The words *co-optors* and *compliants* are coined by the authors and refer to verb co-opting and the noun compliance.

The role of partners in collaborative processes range from a symbolic presence without any real power, to the full power of becoming independent decision-makers (Arnstein 2019). The ethical issue here is the journey from being 'nobodies' trying to become 'somebodies', 'with enough power to make the target institutions responsive to their views, aspirations, and needs' (Arnstein 2019, 25). Worth noting, however, is that this journey is often influenced by those already in power. The levels of powers are not meant to imply that those with minimal power are weak or insignificant to the overall research process. Similarly, it also does not imply that those with the highest power may necessarily meaningfully impact or steer the overall process. An ethical conundrum here is one that links power to responsibility, where a certain correlation is often made between a partner's level of engagement and their consequent level of responsibility and ownership over its process. Certain modes of collaboration may be curated from the topdown that entail a relatively low power distribution across partners, with little to no responsibility or ownership over its process.

3.2. Embodying ethics

After having established that power is negotiated through different understandings of researchers' and various partners' roles, it can be said that ethical collaborative design research intrinsically relies on the humanness of our interactions – or as Akama and Light (2020) express it, 'a capacity to be *responsive with others*' (p. 18). The fluid and embedded nature of ethics considering care and obligation juxtaposes against stricter historical notions of ethics, such as Kant's categorical imperative and the principle of abiding a universal law achieved through logic and reason (Johnson and Cureton 2021). Thus, a researcher's navigation of ethical collaborative process goes beyond formal codes, regulations, and laws; its complexity derives from its situatedness, the ambiguous and messy process of knowledge emergence, and the uncertainty of the unforeseen. This fundamental conceptualisation of research ethics, sensitive to the systems in which they are carried out and affect, provides a springboard into the central lens of this article.

This is embedded in a certain enacting of situated ethics, as we propose, or as Light and Akama (2019) denotes as, 'on-the-spot is often the only way to find out how to be ethical in that situation' (p. 133). Doing collaborative design research in a complex context of materials and beings thus calls for a certain *heightened consciousness* of roles, systems, relations and boundaries involved. Furthering this discussion, d'Anjou (2020) proposes the role of the virtuous researcher guided by an Aristotelian perspective of the good, and what that may mean in different contexts. The good is intrinsically linked to human happiness and flourishing. Not understood as a feeling or sentiment, nor a momentary satisfaction of desires, but rather, an excellence to help others to flourish, which is a virtue (d'Anjou 2020). Thus, virtue theory as a way of thinking about research ethics emphasises the cultivation of the character of the individuals (Robertson and Wagner 2013).

3.3. The art of dialogue and communication

Within these real-world collaborative acts, communication, talking and reasoning play a crucial role for the quality of participation in collaborative design research (Luck 2003;

Molnar and Palmås 2021). Ideally, the communication should be democratic and dialogical, 'open discussion on equal terms' between the participating actors (Florin and Lindhult 2015, 7) – with an underlying question prevailing to what extent can we really be equal? The question resonates with the agonistic approach to collaborative design research which deems that, 'consensus building is not possible or indeed desirable because argumentation and mutual learning is biased by pre-existing power relations' (Zamenopoulos and Alexiou 2018, 23). The challenge here is to facilitate various perspectives to gain diverse knowledge and increase the variety of possible outcomes. In other words, the agonistic approach works towards the sentiment, *'agree to disagree'*. These ideas are closely connected to standpoint epistemology (Harding 1993) and the idea of situated knowledges (Haraway 1988), where the situated activities of community members are seen as valuable starting points for everyone's research and knowledge is seen as objective since it is based on synergies between various perspectives.

The idea of democratic dialogue can also be seen as the foundation for Good (in the Aristotelian sense) collaboration. To explain what we mean, we borrow the words of the former Apple designer Jonathan Ive (2021), during his speech on listening for innovation:

> Curiosity can unite us and form the basis for powerful and joyful collaboration. And crucially, the delight and joy of curiosity and learning can temper our fear of doing something completely new. Lastly, one of the wonderful consequences of being open is that you find yourself actually listening. *To listen well means you need to be quiet* (emphasis added by authors, n.p)

Active listening forces one to consider that something previously deemed irrelevant, might actually be valuable. Often, humans tend to be eager to prepare responses within conversations that it becomes challenging to properly take in what the other person is saying. Especially so, when people with different expertise or backgrounds collaborate, they might experience that what the other person is bringing to table is irrelevant in the context – and thus not valuable listening to. However, we argue that it is important to keep in mind that what is considered meaningful depends on the vantage point (Haraway 1988), and in that sense, everything can be perceived as valuable.

4. A framework for situated ethics – *designing*

The culmination of the section *Deliberating* results in our pantogram (see Figure 2), which is intended to guide researchers' and citizens' alike on how to make sense of situated ethics in the moment. The pantogram visualises collaboration as an act of four measurable (although fluid) dimensions: ethical behaviour, power, participation and reflection. Ideally, both the designer(s) and citizen(s) achieve (or are in the process of striving) high levels of ethical behaviour, power, participation and reflection within a collaborative act (e.g. short term within an isolated incident or long term within a project). However, the designer has the added responsibility of guiding and framing the situation boundary of the collaborative act (i.e. the limiting outer square), while the citizen's responsibility is to engage meaningfully and consistently in the process.

From quadrant 1, into a clockwise orientation in the pantogram: At high ethical behaviour and high reflection, transparency, and authenticity form the pillars of

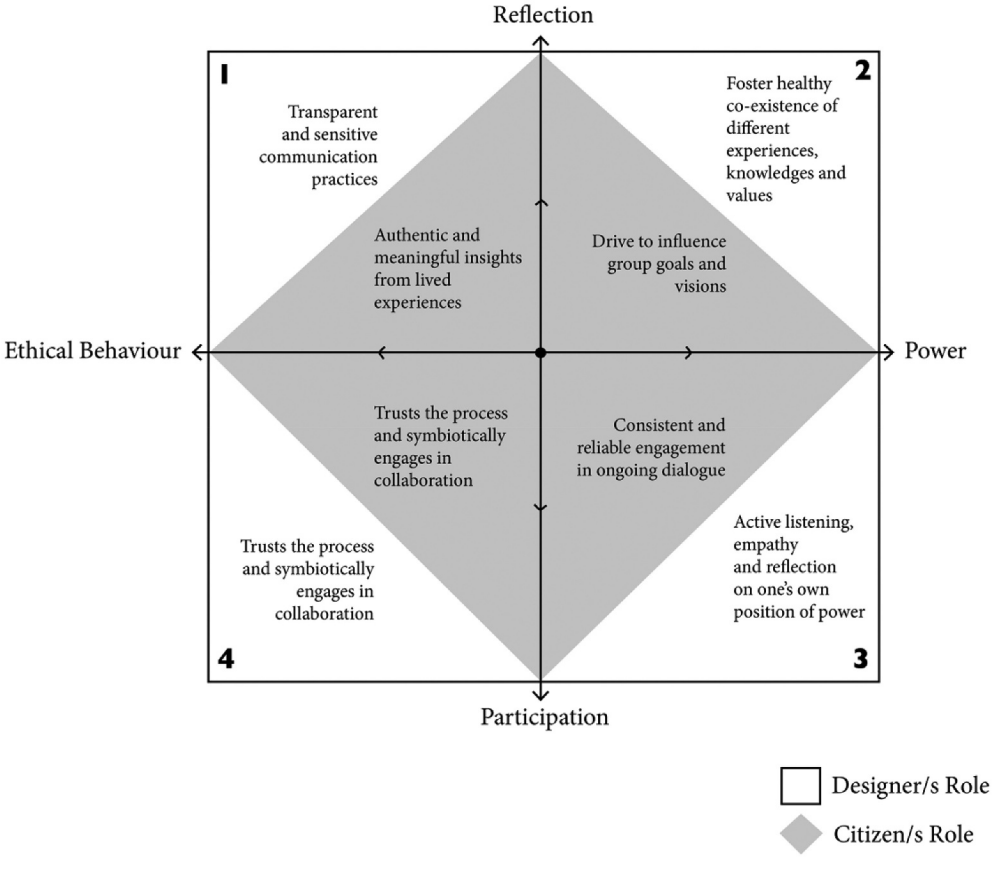


Figure 2. A pantogram of ideal situated ethics from the designer and citizen's perspective. Authors' own illustration.

sharing and communication between the designer(s) and citizen(s). At high reflection and high power, professional mediation and facilitation (on the part of the designer) and the motivation and intention to partake meaningfully in the process (on the part of the citizen), is necessary. In quadrants 1 and 2, citizen engagement can be somewhat isolated or sporadic. At higher levels of power and high participation (quadrant 3), the designer would require self-awareness of one's own role of power and perform servant-leadership, while the citizen is ideally absorbing increasing responsibility within the collaborative process through consistent meaningful participation. Ultimately, the collaborative act at high ethical behaviour and high participation from both parties converges to a single, necessary shared chracterisation: trust for the process (quadrant 4).

The framework offers performative cues on both the parts of the designer and citizen while being open enough for diverse interpretations and sensitive applications in different contexts. It is important any researcher using this framework must balance their subjective insights with empirical evidence, ensuring that the introspection process serves as a supplement rather than a substitute for rigorous methodology (Adeoye and Lere Omiwole 2024). For example, this balance can be achieved through systematic

reflective practices, such as maintaining research journals, and peer discussions, and engaging with different perspectives that challenge personal viewpoints (Adeoye and Lere Omiwole 2024). The framework could then support researchers along the (messy) process of collaborative knowledge production, mirroring the persistent challenge of carrying out a sort of situated ethics – in other words, ethical actions that can be justly and responsibly carried out over spontaneous, serendipitous, and organic developments.

To translate these performative cues into concrete examples of how they may be applied in context, the following section depicts a case study of how we, the authors, applied these reflective check-ins during two different collaborative activities within a larger local urban design project.

5. Case study: applying the framework – *doing*

5.1. Open-ended survey

The first application of the framework was within a qualitative survey to learn from people's diverse experiences of public squares around the world. Through the survey, the participants shared their stories and memories as answers to 10 open-ended questions. A total of 101 participants responded to the survey.

For the process to be ethical, we understood that we needed to deliver on balanced and sensitive communication practices, but also navigate ways to learn around the topic without imposing our own limited set of understandings or projecting our own beliefs onto the participants. This collaborative activity is thus exemplary of performing situated ethics in quadrant 1 (see Figure 3), since high reflection and high ethical behaviour intersect through transparent and sensitive communication practices from the side of the designer, and authentic and meaningful lived experiences are shared from the side of the citizen. From the perspective of the citizen, the capacity to push for greater participation (i.e. increased responsibility and involvement) in the event of a survey is generally limited, as is the negotiation of power. Thus, the designer generally takes a lead role within the creation of a survey event (i.e. full participation) and has high power over how the answers are interpreted. Since those who answered the survey did not have the possibility to impact how their answers were understood or interpreted, the analysis process required careful reflection and an awareness of one's own position of power on our part who were analysing the answers.

In particular, we engaged in a systematic reflective practice of personal research journalling and brainstorming, which we then discussed between each other iteratively along the research process, and also within the wider research community in order to challenge any existing preconceptions within our viewpoints and to further broaden our thinking, as proposed by critical introspective researchers (Adeoye and Lere Omiwole 2024). We were aware of the potential of researchers' bias as well (Chenail 2011). The researchers' bias refers to how researchers (subconsciously or unintentionally) may seek data that confirms their current understandings rather than discovering new unknown perspectives. Moreover, as aptly captured by Oliver, Serovich, and Mason (2005), '[d]ialogue is rarely the simple exchange of ideas … Talk is peppered with verbal and non-verbal signals that can change the tenor of

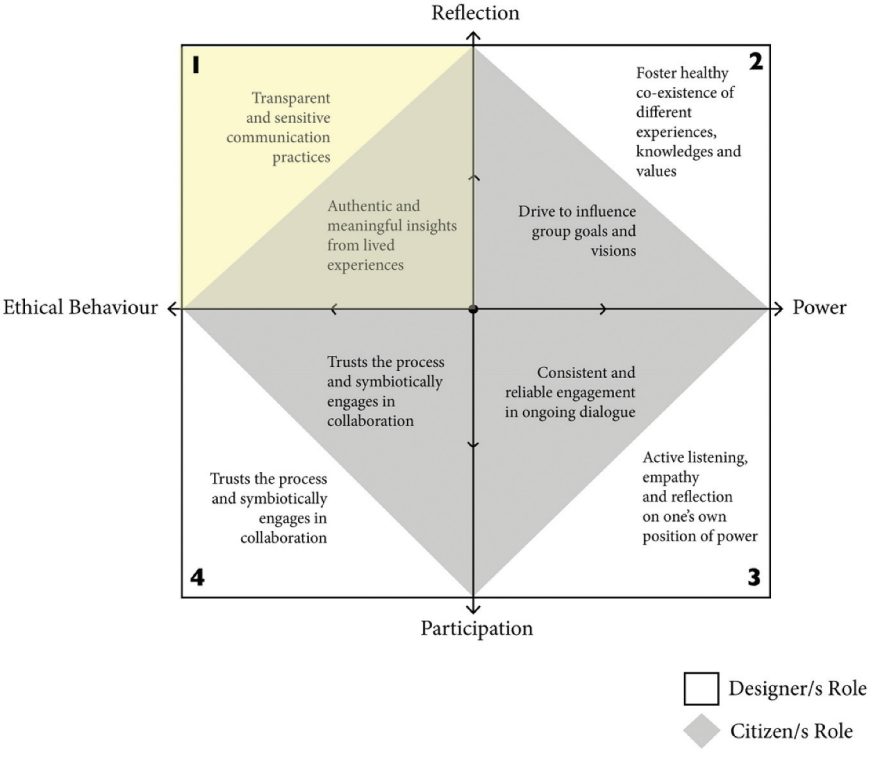


Figure 3. Position of the survey in relation to the pantogram. Authors' own illustration.

conversations and meaning' (p. 1276). While we understood the importance of active listening to subtle cues in conversations that may provide for a more nuanced understanding of the topic at hand, one question still remained: How may we condense rich conversations, as well as apply such skilful reflectivity, in the context of a flat and unforgiving two-dimensional online survey?

While we were aware of the problematics posed by the use of digital technologies, we still chose to conduct the survey online for two main reasons: the Covid-19 pandemic limited physical hand-outs and meet-ups, and we had wanted as many diverse responses from all over the world as possible to learn and understand from as many perspectives as possible. We eventually utilised all our reflections above to shape a survey created on Google Forms. We shaped open-ended questions to allow subjective sharing of experiences in urban squares. We ensured the openness of the questions took multiple forms: the questions could be answered freely without word limits, and a certain vagueness, such as the wording 'tell us about . . . ', towards the formulation of the questions allowed for several different interpretations, thereby allowing the participant to share according to their own experiences. This was a direct attempt to offer the choice of *what* and *how* to share, to the participant, so that we might reduce the risk of the researcher bias (Chenail 2011).

Fundamentally, the opportunity and ability for participants *to tell their own stories, in their own words* is a way of participating with virtue. Following an Aristotelian conceptualisation of virtue, means that the act of collaborative design research is empowering; 'it is a way to actualise one's and others' capacity within the realm of the community' (d'Anjou

2020, 30). Thus, the researcher's responsibility towards meticulous documentation, respect and freedom towards the process of interpersonal sharing is a way-of-being that would allow for the collaborative knowledge production for the Good.

5.2. Pop-up workshop

The second application of the framework is at a pop-up workshop in Kronan, conducted in collaboration with local inhabitants living in the neighbourhood. The pop-up workshop was characterised by the flexible drop-in approach that enabled people to participate spontaneously and as much and long it suited them. The aim was to explore the needs of the inhabitants and create a platform to discuss their visions for the future urban square in the area. To improve outreach efforts for the workshop, we selected a location based on several criteria: accessible for people with mobility issues, space for physical distancing during Covid-19, a weekend day (Saturday) for enhanced participation and time of day that had high foot traffic. Furthermore, it was important for us that the activity performed was fun yet simple, so that children, elderly, families and individuals of all expertise and backgrounds may join in. The workshop lasted approximately 2 hours and received 25 participants. Two large sheets of paper were hung on the wall with broad, overarching questions: 'What do you want to do in the new square?' and 'How could renewable energy be part of the activities in the new square?'. Creative activity filled the boards with cut-out inspirational images, open-ended notes, and quick ideas on post-its, as well as connecting marker scribbles and sketches (see Figure 4).



Figure 4. Pop-up workshop. Image taken with explicit consent. Photo by authors.

Compared to the survey, the face-to-face nature of the communication in the workshop entailed a greater need on the part of the researcher to create an atmosphere of trust – an incubator for organic conversations and spontaneous thoughts and ideas. Trust may be created through a show of vulnerability and increased engagement – not only the part of the citizen but also the part of the researcher, in order to display willingness to reciprocate such sharing (Peschl and Fundneider 2014). We made it explicit that there were no right or wrong answers, and that we were thankful for all and any contribution. That the idea was to explore *together*. Thus, it was crucial for us to remain conscious and patient about the process's development, reiterating that the goal was on learning and building upon the inhabitants' lived experiences, as opposed to solution-finding. Here, power was relegated to the partners, for them to determine how the process could and would develop – we pronounced ourselves basic facilitators of the activity that also in some occasion aided in translating partners' ideas onto paper. Therefore, this collaborative activity is exemplary of quadrant 2 in the pantogram (see Figure 5).

Although the question remains: How may trust be developed over such short, instantaneous meetings, and what are the ethical implications involved? Many were curious, perhaps even slightly apprehensive, about their true contribution to the activity – on whether the municipality might take their ideas seriously. For that reason, we were explicit that we could not promise any specific developments in accordance and focused on that the information would be relayed to the municipality as a result and continued to be engaged with in further workshops. Furthermore, tensions rose when an inhabitant

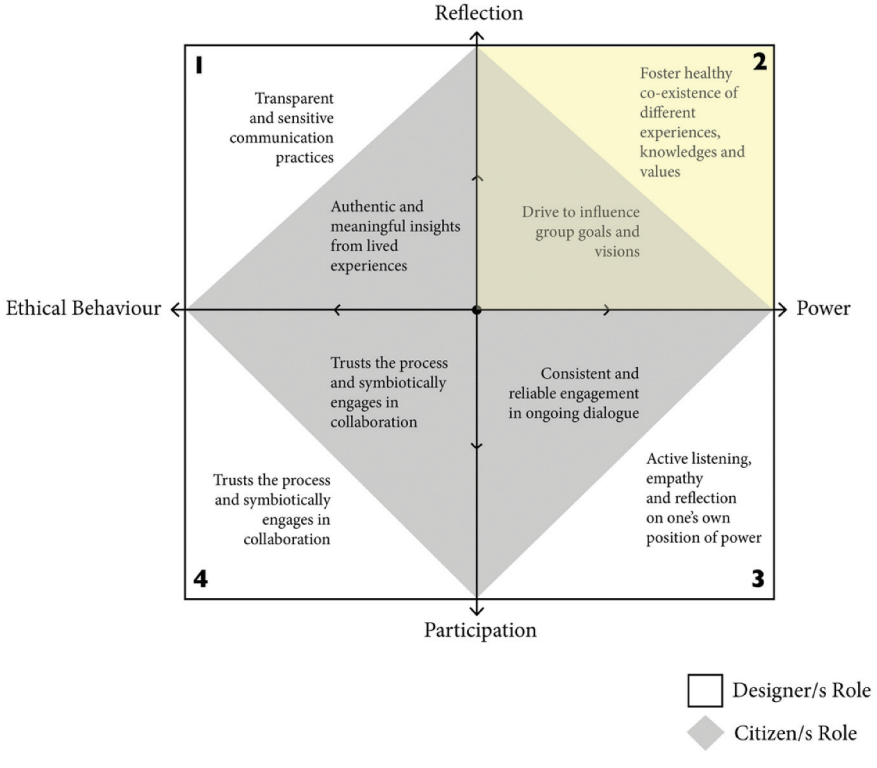


Figure 5. Position of the workshop in relation to the pantogram. authors' own illustration.

became visibly agitated at the questions that were on the posters. 'You are asking the wrong questions!' (Participant A, 2020) was his response when we invited him into the activity. We found this an opportunity to be open and listen with empathy. Instead of denying his position, we took his feedback and opened a different dialogue with him with two questions he thought we should be asking instead, 'How do we keep our public places alive?' and 'How do we foster care and maintenance over our existing spaces?'. He was primarily concerned with issues of responsibility and was doubtful that the municipality could fulfill its promises on an attractive public square. Such meaningful participation is a prime example of how power could be negotiated between designer and citizen in a fluid and symbiotic manner: we listened as he explained, and he listened as we explained. No ego involved.

Proper documentation was important, yet difficult to achieve, during this collaborative activity. Since the atmosphere of creative and free expression was the priority, it was difficult to accurately capture all and whole ideas onto paper. This, however, might be a valuable sacrifice that led to deeper relations and higher trust and sharing, since participants understood that we prioritised being fully engaged in conversations as opposed to note-taking. Furthermore, this *whole presence* in conversations also enabled us to enter a sort of serendipitous creativity with the participant – a back-and-forth banter, if you will – where inspiration sparked more inspiration, leading to a flow of ideas, albeit, not thoroughly formulated (Akama and Light 2020). The face-to-face nature of the workshop provided a more nuanced understanding of the ideas and comments delivered, since the intricacies of speech and body language combined to contribute to better interpersonal communication. Reverting back to the fundamental idea of co-auditing in the previous application of the framework (within the survey), it was nevertheless important that the partners were able *to tell their own stories, in their own words*, and that the researcher's role was to actively listen, sensitively converse, and document.

Figure 6 shows the second-round of analysis over the workshop materials, vis-à-vis a discussion of our own personal learnings and experience of the event. The analysis was conducted iteratively over a course of three sessions, to ensure our introspective transparency towards one another, and iteratively challenging all viewpoints. A thematic analysis was conducted over the post-its and notes on the posters (Braun and Clarke 2006) and then synthesised further into themes combined with our own introspections.

6. Discussion

This article contributes to knowledge-building at the nexus of ethics and collaborative design. We first *deliberated* on what it means to do an ethical collaboration, leading to a solid foundation on which *designing* the framework for situated ethics was possible. Consequently, we described a case study that exemplifies *doing* situated ethics through concrete examples. To reiterate, this research supports and builds upon the work of Drain and Sanders (2019) Collaborative System Model, which outlines a further need for integrating personal and social complexities within the collaborative design process. Furthermore, this research elucidates what performing *situated ethics* could mean in the field of designing for place, policy, and the public sector.

This research aimed to illuminate on the question: *How might design researchers more deeply deliberate their ethical positionings, so that they might increase their situated*

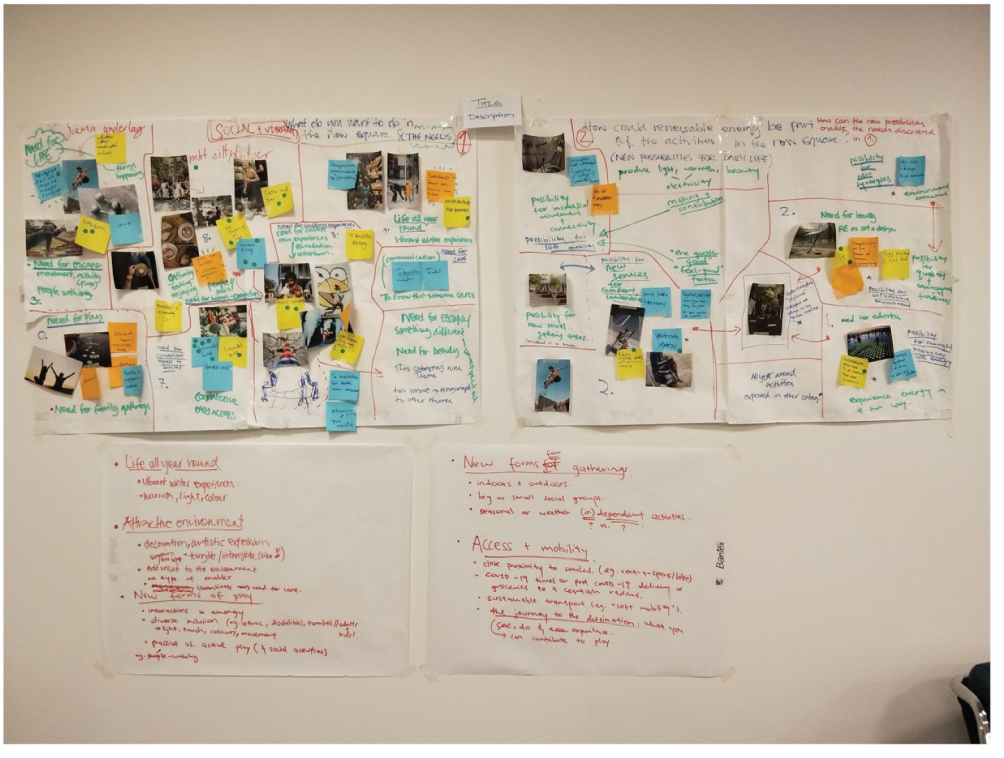


Figure 6. Analysis of workshop materials. Photo by authors.

awareness and reflectivity when collaborating with various partners? A synthesis of the case study experience as well as the pantogram offers ethical ways-of-being in response to this research question:

- Openness, clarity, and transparency in one's role and expertise
- Inner motivation towards self-awareness and development
- Humility (e.g. acceptance of not knowing)
- Embodying and expressing respect (e.g. 'agree to disagree')

These ideals require a shift in the mindset from being the expert to being a servant and enabler (Peschl and Fundneider 2014). While these ideals are sometimes difficult to achieve in messy real-life situations, a certain willingness to accept one's and other's shortcomings – as well as continuously recognising the efforts towards self-development – is part and parcel doing ethics in collaborative design research processes. In line with virtue ethics, it also requires a willingness to work towards personal development – to work with one's own personal limitations with the help from others. Becoming aware of the deeper layers of one's own inner world and thus developing new kinds of skills, is crucial for quality collaboration with others (Hakio and Mattelmäki 2019). These skills refer to inner abilities and experiences of, 'connecting to self, sensing the interconnectedness of life, sensing and speculating from the perspective of otherness or listening from the collective whole' (p.19). We propose that these abilities can be cultivated in environments of curiosity that allows several ideas to co-exist.

6.1. Limitations and opportunities

The findings are to be seen as initial insights and seeds that require further cultivation and research involving several situations and actors. In this article, we took the perspective of the design researcher, and thus further research is needed to explore various partners experiences on how the designer/researcher's way of being and acting may enhance participation. For example, Xue, van Kooten, and Desmet (2025) discuss six categories of ethical risks in autoethnography:

- psychological or emotional risks,
- physical risks that involve harm,
- privacy risks related to the unconsented disclosure of personal information of others,
- social risks such as the potential damages to the relationships between the researcher and their close others,
- career and economic risks following potential negative reputational and professional consequences that the researcher may face, and finally,
- integrity risks, such as the potential for misrepresentation.

We are aware that these potential risks are also applicable to our framework and that a heightened awareness to these risks would allow for a more sensitive and careful use of the framework.

Despite the shortcomings, we see several opportunities. With further testing, development, and discussions, the framework has potential to evolve over time, to extend and cater to various uses and contexts in which researchers would want to develop their ethical practices. For example, in living labs where researchers collaborate with various stakeholders to prepare and navigate fragile interpersonal relations in an ethical manner. Municipalities and alike might also benefit from the framework in citizen dialogues and other collaborative planning interventions. The situated ethics framework may be used both by individual researchers and research teams, within planning projects (reflection-before-action), during the collaborative activities with participants to perform ethics-in-action (reflection-in-action), and when harvesting the lessons learned (reflection-on-action) (Schön 1983). In line with Akama and Light (2020), we suggest that more thoroughly planned and focused activities that correspond to the roles of the participants may lead to more meaningful participation and applicable results. Furthermore, due to its universal human needs' underpinnings, the framework may be applied in various cultural contexts.

Moreover, time has shown us, thus far, that the forms in which the research collaborations take place are rapidly changing. New technologies enable collaborations beyond tangible socio-material settings of physical meetings, seeping into the digital realm bridging spatialities and temporalities. Collaboration today does not necessarily point to being instantaneous or physical, it could be asynchronous and digital – such as in the case of our use of an online survey. The effects of Covid-19 is one example in which researchers have been challenged to creatively explore new ways of collaborating across time-space boundaries. Emerging technologies and new innovations will continue to shape our lifestyles and ways of doing collaboration –

shifting and transforming the challenge of conducting ethics in a different way, where the dynamics of participant power may evolve and manifest into new needs and forms that are unprecedented. We believe the framework we offer is flexible enough to cater to such uncertain and transitional nature of collaborative knowledge production, ascertaining ethical engagement irrespective of the medium of performance. The openness of the framework – and the centrality of the researcher's ethical way-of-being – allows for the framework to be interpreted differently in different contexts and means, enabling longevity of use and future relevance. Future learnings point towards further relevant questions: *Who (humans)* or *what (other living entities/machines)* are we essentially collaborating with? How would power and ethical collaboration look like then?

7. Conclusion

Finally, the situated ethics framework proposed in this article does not ask for perfection, nor does it measure ethical quality – it encourages individual and collective betterment. The framework is not perfect in the same special way that each collaborative act is different, messy, and complex. As forewarned, the framework does not attempt to offer normative guidelines towards ethics, but rather, offers insights about way-of-being and thinking in collaborative design research. Thus, as an inner activity, a certain zooming in and zooming out is required to be able to locate oneself in relation to the whole. Some potential users of the framework may find the suggestions too generic and vague, whereas others may prefer the challenge and freedom to develop their own situated actions inspired by the suggestions. In either case, the article contributes to the ongoing – and necessary – discourse on ethics and collaborative design, striving towards flourishing and well-being of all involved.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Funding

This was supported by the VINNOVA [2018-04102],2021XSC-0086.

ORCID

Suzanna Törnroth http://orcid.org/0000-0001-7598-3310
Minna Eronen http://orcid.org/0000-0001-8006-4941

References

Adeoye, M. A., and J. Lere Omiwole. 2024. "The Critical Role of Introspective Analysis in Modern Research Practices." *Educational Researcher Journal* 1 (2): 32–44. https://doi.org/10.71288/educationalresearcherjournal.v1i2.12.

Akama, Y., and A. Light. 2020. "Readiness for Contingency: Punctuation, Poise, and Codesign." *Codesign* 16 (1): 17–28.
Arnstein, S. R. 1969. "A Ladder of Citizen Participation." *Journal of the American Institute of Planners* 35 (4): 216–224. https://doi.org/10.1080/01944366908977225.
Arnstein, S. R. 2019. "A Ladder of Citizen Participation." *Journal of the American Planning Association* 85 (1): 24–34. https://doi.org/10.1080/01944363.2018.1559388.
Banks, S. 2012. *Ethics and Values in Social Work*. 4th ed. Palgrave Macmillan.
Braun, V., and V. Clarke. 2006. "Using Thematic Analysis in Psychology." *Qualitative Research in Psychology* 3 (2): 77–101. https://doi.org/10.1191/1478088706qp063oa.
Chenail, R. J. 2011. "Interviewing the Investigator: Strategies for Addressing Instrumentation and Researcher Bias Concerns in Qualitative Research." *The Qualitative Report* 16 (1): 255–262.
d'Anjou, P. 2020. *Ethical Design Intelligence: The Virtuous Designer*. Routledge.
DiSalvo, C. 2022. *Design as Democratic Inquiry: Putting Experimental Civics into Practice*. The MIT Press.
Drain, A., and E. B.-N. Sanders. 2019. "A Collaboration System Model for Planning and Evaluating Participatory Design Projects." *International Journal of Design* 13 (3): 39–52.
Florin, U., and E. Lindhult. 2015. "Norms and Ethics: Prerequisites for Excellence in Coproduction." Paper presented at Högskola och Samhälle i Samverkan HSS´15, Kalmar, Sweden, May 28. https://urn.kb.se/resolve?urn=urn:nbn:se:mdh:diva-32791.
Frauenberger, C., M. Rauhala, and G. Fitzpatrick. 2016. "In-Action Ethics." *Interacting With Computers* 29 (2): 220–236. https://doi.org/10.1093/iwc/iww024.
Hakio, K., and T. Mattelmäki. 2019. "Future Skills of Design for Sustainability: An Awareness-Based Co-Creation Approach." *Sustainability* 11 (19): 5247. https://doi.org/10.3390/su11195247.
Haraway, D. 1988. "Situated Knowledges: The Science Question in Feminism and the Privilege of Partial Perspective." *Feminist Studies* 14 (3): 575–599. https://doi.org/10.2307/3178066.
Harding, S. 1993. "Rethinking Standpoint Epistemology: What Is 'Strong Objectivity'?" In *Feminist Epistemologies*, edited by L. Alcoff and E. Potter, 49–82. Routledge.
Herr, K., and G. L. Anderson. 2014. *The Action Research Dissertation: A Guide for Students and Faculty*. Sage publications.
Ive, J. 2021. "*Commencement Honorary Doctorate Address*." California College of the Arts. May 13, 2021. [Video]. Youtube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gr3GKcwG9s8.
Johnson, R., and A. Cureton. 2021. Kant's Moral Philosophy. *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (Spring 2021 Edition), Edward N. Zalta edited by.
Kimbell, L., L. Richardson, R. Mazé, and C. Durose. 2022. "Design for Public Policy: Embracing Uncertainty and Hybridity in Mapping Future Research." In *DRS2022: Bilbao, 25 June – 3 July 2022*, Bilbao, Spain, edited by D. Lockton, S. Lenzi, P. Hekkert, A. Oak, J. Sádaba, and P. Lloyd. Design Research Society. https://doi.org/10.21606/drs.2022.303.
Light, A., and Y. Akama. 2019. "The Nature of 'Obligation' in Doing Design with Communities: Participation, Politics and Care." In *Tricky Design: The Ethics of Things*, chapter 8, edited by T. Fischer and L. Gamman, 232. Bloomsbury Visual Arts. https://doi.org/10.5040/9781474277211.ch-009.
Lloyd, P. 2009. "Ethical Imagination and Design." *Design Studies* 30 (2): 154–168. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.destud.2008.12.004.
Luck, R. 2003. "Dialogue in Participatory Design." *Design Studies* 24 (6): 523–535. https://doi.org/10.1016/S0142-694X(03)00040-1.
Molnar, S., and K. Palmås. 2021. "Dissonance and Diplomacy: Coordination of Conflicting Values in Urban Co-Design." *Codesign* 18 (4): 416–430. https://doi.org/10.1080/15710882.2021.1968441.
Oliver, D. G., J. M. Serovich, and T. L. Mason. 2005. "Constraints and Opportunities With Interview Transcription: Towards Reflection in Qualitative Research." *Social Forces* 84 (2): 1273–1289. https://doi.org/10.1353/sof.2006.0023.
Peschl, M. F., and T. Fundneider. 2014. "Designing and Enabling Spaces for Collaborative Knowledge Creation and Innovation: From Managing to Enabling Innovation as

Socio-Epistemological Technology." *Computers in Human Behavior* 37:346–359. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2012.05.027.

Pirinen, A., K. Savolainen, S. Hyysalo, and T. Mattelmäki. 2022. "Design Enters the City: Requisites and Points of Friction in Deepening Public Sector Design." *International Journal of Design* 16 (3): 119. https://doi.org/10.57698/v16i3.01.

Robertson, T., and I. Wagner. 2013. "Ethics: Engagement, Representation and Politics-in-Action." In *Routledge International Handbook of Participatory Design*, edited by Robertson, 64–85. Routledge.

Rule, P., and V. M. John. 2015. "A Necessary Dialogue: Theory in Case Study Research." *International Journal of Qualitative Methods* 14 (4). https://doi.org/10.1177/1609406915611575.

Sanders, E. B. N., and P. J. Stappers. 2008. "Co-Creation and the New Landscapes of Design." *CoDesign: International Journal of CoCreation in Design and the Arts* 4 (1): 5–18. https://doi.org/10.1080/15710880701875068.

Schön, D. 1983. *The Reflective Practitioner*. New York: Basic Books.

Steen, M. 2013. "Co-Design as a Process of Joint Inquiry and Imagination." *Design Issues* 29 (2): 16–28. https://doi.org/10.1162/DESI_a_00207.

Xue, H., and P. M. A. Desmet. 2019. "Researcher Introspection for Experience-Driven Design Research." *Design Studies* 63:37–64. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.destud.2019.03.001.

Xue, H., K. van Kooten, and P. M. A. Desmet. 2025. "A Consent for Myself/Ourselves: Designing for Responsible Use of Autoethnography." *Codesign*: 1–17. https://doi.org/10.1080/15710882.2025.2456609.

Zamenopoulos, T., and K. Alexiou. 2018. *Co-design as Collaborative Research. Connected Communities Foundation Series*. Bristol: University of Bristol / AHRC Connected Communities Programme.

Zamenopoulos, T., B. Lam, K. Alexiou, M. Kelemen, S. De Sousa, S. Moffat, and M. Phillips. 2021. "Types, Obstacles and Sources of Empowerment in Co-Design: The Role of Shared Material Objects and Processes." *Codesign* 17 (2): 139–158. https://doi.org/10.1080/15710882.2019.1605383.